

II8 Mary, mother of Jesus

The woman of Nazareth who said yes to God, raised his Son, stood at the cross, and prayed with the first church.

Mary was an ordinary Jewish woman of Nazareth, engaged to Joseph, when Gabriel told her she would conceive by the Holy Ghost and bear the Son of God. She asked one honest question and then gave herself to God's plan. Her life held great joy and deep pain: a birth in Bethlehem, flight to Egypt, and later the cross. Scripture shows her pondering what she did not yet understand, pointing others to her Son, and praying with his followers after he rose. Christians honour her in different ways, but all can learn from her trust and faithfulness.

At a glance

Name	Hebrew <i>Miriam</i> , like Moses' sister; Greek <i>Maria</i>
Family	Betrothed, then married, to Joseph (Matthew 1:18–25)
Children	Jesus; also "brethren" and sisters (Matthew 13:55–56)
Relative	Elizabeth, mother of John the Baptist (Luke 1:36)
When	Jesus born c. 6–4 BC; Mary living c. AD 30 (Acts 1:14)
Key places	Nazareth, Bethlehem, Egypt, Cana, Jerusalem
Key people	Joseph, Elizabeth, Simeon, the disciple Jesus loved
Last mention	Praying with the disciples before Pentecost (Acts 1:14)

"Behold the handmaid of the Lord; be it unto me according to thy word."

Luke 1:38, KJV

The life of Mary, mother of Jesus

Dates are approximate (BC or AD). Scripture does not give Mary's age at any point.

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|--|---|
| c. 7–5 BC
<i>In Nazareth</i> | <div style="display: flex; align-items: center;"><div style="margin-right: 10px;">●</div><div>Gabriel's message
The angel tells Mary she will bear Jesus, the Son of the Highest. She asks how, hears of the Holy Ghost, and consents. <i>Luke 1:26–38</i></div></div> |
| c. 7–5 BC
<i>Hill country of Judah</i> | <div style="display: flex; align-items: center;"><div style="margin-right: 10px;">●</div><div>Visits Elizabeth
Elizabeth blesses her, and Mary answers with a song of praise, often called the Magnificat. <i>Luke 1:39–56</i></div></div> |
| c. 6–4 BC
<i>Bethlehem</i> | <div style="display: flex; align-items: center;"><div style="margin-right: 10px;">●</div><div>Gives birth to Jesus
She lays her firstborn son in a manger. Shepherds come, and Mary keeps these things in her heart. <i>Luke 2:1–20</i></div></div> |
| c. 6–4 BC
<i>Forty days old</i> | <div style="display: flex; align-items: center;"><div style="margin-right: 10px;">●</div><div>The temple
They offer the poor family's two birds. Simeon warns that a sword will pierce her own soul. <i>Luke 2:21–39; Leviticus 12:2–8</i></div></div> |
| c. 6–4 BC
<i>Under Herod</i> | <div style="display: flex; align-items: center;"><div style="margin-right: 10px;">●</div><div>Flight to Egypt
After the wise men's visit, Joseph takes Mary and Jesus to Egypt, then settles in Nazareth. <i>Matthew 2:1–23</i></div></div> |
| Jesus aged 12 | <div style="display: flex; align-items: center;"><div style="margin-right: 10px;">●</div><div>Lost and found
After three days' searching they find Jesus in the temple, about his Father's business. <i>Luke 2:41–51</i></div></div> |
| c. AD 28–30
<i>Jesus' ministry</i> | <div style="display: flex; align-items: center;"><div style="margin-right: 10px;">●</div><div>Cana and after
At Cana she tells the servants to do whatever Jesus says. Later she and his brothers seek him. <i>John 2:1–12; Mark 3:31–35</i></div></div> |
| c. AD 30 or 33
<i>Cross and upper room</i> | <div style="display: flex; align-items: center;"><div style="margin-right: 10px;">●</div><div>Faithful to the end
Jesus entrusts her to the disciple he loved. After the ascension she prays with the apostles. <i>John 19:25–27; Acts 1:14</i></div></div> |

Key activities

Christians differ over Mary's later role. Roman Catholic and Orthodox Christians honour her in ways many Protestants do not. This chapter follows what the text says.

- 1 Believed God's word.** Told she would bear God's Son, she answered, "Behold the handmaid of the Lord." Elizabeth called her blessed because she believed. *Luke 1:38, 45*
- 2 Asked an honest question.** She asked, "How shall this be, seeing I know not a man?" and was answered, "For with God nothing shall be impossible." *Luke 1:34-37*
- 3 Sang of God's mercy.** Her song praises God who scatters the proud, lifts the lowly, fills the hungry, and remembers his promise to Abraham. *Luke 1:46-55*
- 4 Faced hardship and possible disgrace.** She conceived before her marriage was completed and gave birth far from home, with "no room for them in the inn." *Matthew 1:18-19; Luke 2:4-7*
- 5 Pondered in her heart.** Twice Luke says she treasured up what she saw and heard, even when she did not understand it. *Luke 2:19, 51*
- 6 Kept the Law.** She and Joseph circumcised Jesus, presented him in the temple, and went up to Jerusalem every year for Passover. *Luke 2:21-24, 41*
- 7 Fled as a refugee.** She went with Joseph to Egypt to save the child from Herod. *Matthew 2:13-15*
- 8 Pointed others to Jesus.** At Cana she said, "Whatsoever he saith unto you, do it." *John 2:5*
- 9 Stood by the cross.** She was near the cross with other women when most of the disciples had fled. *John 19:25; Mark 14:50*
- 10 Prayed with the church.** She continued in prayer with the apostles, the women and Jesus' brothers in Jerusalem. *Acts 1:14*

Across Scripture

Direct references first. Echoes are study links. Christians differ on whether Jesus' "brethren" were Mary's children, Joseph's, or cousins; stories of her later life and assumption are later tradition, not Scripture.

Old Testament

Isaiah 7:14	"A virgin shall conceive," fulfilled in Mary (Matthew 1:22-23)
Echo: 1 Samuel 2:1-10	Hannah's song, strongly echoed in Mary's
Echo: Genesis 3:15	The promised seed, fulfilled in her Son (Galatians 4:4)

New Testament

Matthew 1:16-25; 2:11-21	Joseph's wife and mother of the child Jesus
Luke 1:26-56; 2:1-52	The fullest account of her story
Mark 3:31-35; 6:3	She seeks Jesus; he is "the son of Mary"
John 2:1-12; 19:25-27	At the first sign and at the cross
Acts 1:14	Her last mention by name

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What did Mary say to Gabriel, and what did she ask (Luke 1:34, 38)?
2. *Understand:* Simeon warned that a sword would pierce Mary's soul (Luke 2:35). Where in her story do you see that happen?
3. *Apply:* Mary "pondered" what she did not understand. What is one thing God is doing in your life that you need to ponder rather than rush to explain?
4. *Apply:* "Whatsoever he saith unto you, do it." What is one thing Jesus has said that you will obey this week?